



# **HOW TO USE THE CORRECT GRAMMAR IN IELTS SPEAKING!**

**KEITH O'HARE**

# Helping you Become a Confident English Speaker

*Many IELTS students lack confidence in their speaking skills.*

*The Keith Speaking Academy helps you develop your speaking skills so you can face the examiner with confidence and ace the IELTS test.*

*This PDF is one of many that Keith has developed to help you do this.*



*Keith has been working in international education for over 20 years as a teacher, teacher trainer, and education manager.*

*He has helped over 40,000 students prepare for their IELTS Speaking test with his online courses.*

Using the correct grammar in IELTS Speaking is really important if you want to get a high score.

Did you know 90% of students make a grammar mistake in their initial responses during the test? [See the top 5 speaking grammar mistakes students make.](#)

This PDF will guide you through the main grammatical tenses you can use to ace your IELTS Speaking test.



## The Big Question: Which Tense Should I Use?

The truth is, there's no '**correct tense**' you should use for any particular answer. The tense you should use depends on what you want to convey. However, you can generally categorise your responses into three situations:

- Talking about the present
- Talking about the past
- Talking about the future

Let's look at each of these situations and explore the tenses you can use.



## Talking About the Present Time

When discussing the present, you have a variety of tenses at your disposal. These include:

- Present Simple
- Present Continuous
- Present Perfect Simple
- Present Perfect Continuous

### Examples to Guide You

Suppose you're asked in **IELTS Speaking Part 1**, "**Where do you live now?**" Here's how you can answer using different tenses:

- **I live in Spain.** (*Present Simple: Present state now*)
- **I'm living in Spain at the moment.** (*Present Continuous: Temporary Situation*)
- **I have lived in Spain for 5 years.** (*Present Perfect Simple: Ongoing with focus on time; 5 years*)
- **I have been living in Spain for 5 years.** (*Present Perfect Continuous: Ongoing with focus on activity; living in Spain*)

All these tenses are correct and can be used in various combinations to answer the question effectively.



## Model Answer

- I **am living** in Spain now, I actually moved here for work reasons. I **have been living** here for 5 years and I really enjoy it, it's a great place to live.

### TIP: MAKE IT PERSONAL

To ensure you're actively using this knowledge, whenever you are **practicing speaking English tenses**, try to make sentences that are true for you.



## Talking About Past Time

When it comes to discussing the past, you can use:

- Past Simple
- Past Continuous
- Past Perfect
- Used to
- Would

### Examples to Illuminate

If you're asked about your **childhood**, last **job**, or a previous **holiday**, you can use the following tenses:

- **I **lived** in Manchester when I was younger.** (*Past Simple*)
- **I **was living** in Manchester when I met my girlfriend.**  
(*Past Continuous: Overlapping events, good for starting stories in IELTS Speaking Part 2 questions*)
- **I **had** actually **moved** to Manchester 2 years before I met my girlfriend.** (*Past Perfect: Explaining a reason for past situation*)
- **I **used to live** in Manchester.** (*Used to: No longer true*)
- **When I lived in Manchester, I **would** catch the bus every day to school.** (*Would: Past habits*)

## Model Answer

- I **met** my very first girlfriend about 10 years ago. I **was living** in London when I **met** her in a museum. It was pure luck, because I **had never been** to that museum before. In fact, I **never used** to go to museums, but I **went** to that one to see a Van Gogh exposition someone **had recommended**.

### TIP: CHANGE ONE WORD

To activate your knowledge, whenever you are practicing tenses, try changing one word in the phrase to make it true for you.





## Talking About the Future

For future scenarios, you can use:

- Future with Will
- Future with Going to
- Present Continuous
- Might, May, Could

### Examples to Enlighten

You may be asked about the future in **IELTS Speaking Part 3 questions**, but it may also come up in Part 1. For example, If asked, **"Will you change your job in the future?"** you can respond with:

- **I don't think I *will* change my job just yet. It's not great, but I think it *will* get better** (*Future with Will: If you decide now or make a prediction*)
- **I *am not going to* change my job just yet.** (*Future with Going to: Something decided and planned*)
- **I *am starting* a new job next week.** (*Present Continuous: Planned and scheduled*)
- **I *might* change my job, if I find a better one.** (*Modals: Might, May, Could to express future possibility*)

## Model Answer

- I don't think I **will** change my job just yet. It's not great, but I think it **will** get better. In fact, I **am going to** ask to take on more responsibilities so I can gain more experience. That **might** help me get a promotion in the future.

### TIP: WORK ON INTONATION AND PRONUNCIATION

To truly master grammar, practice speaking it out loud and focus on your **intonation and pronunciation**.



## Conclusion

Remember, these tenses are not ones you **must** use, but ones you **can** use. The key is to be **flexible** and adapt your language to what you want to express.

For a more in-depth guide to which tenses to use in IELTS Speaking, and awesome videos to help you activate correct grammar when speaking, check out the online course [Fluent Grammar for IELTS Speaking](#). Good luck!



**Check out the course below**

**[FLUENT GRAMMAR FOR IELTS SPEAKING](#)**

